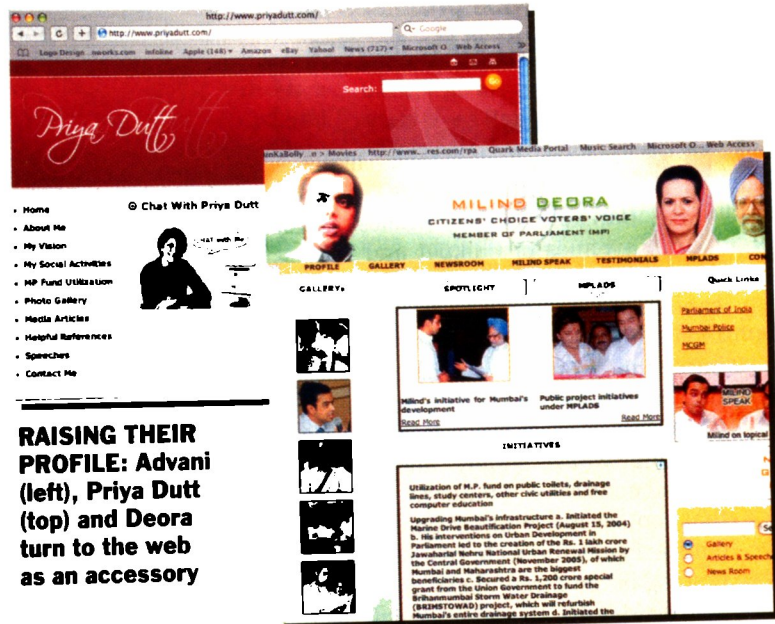
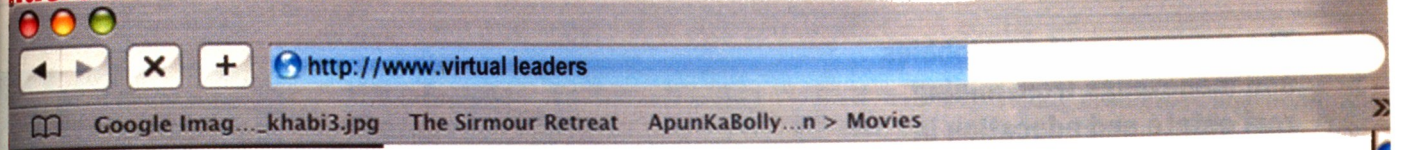
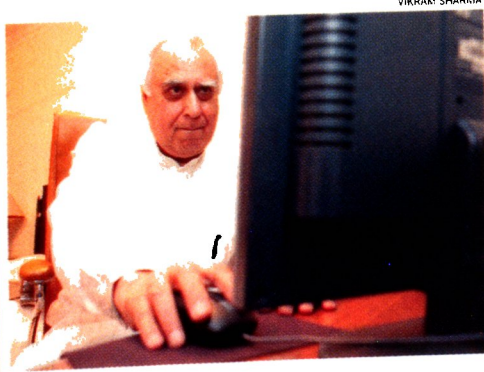




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YASIN DAR



VIKRAM SHARMA

THEY'VE GOT MAIL: Abdullah (left) and Sibal track their online personalities

Citizen's Choice and Voter's Voice. He has also posted rave endorsements from Mumbai's leading lights. There is a good reason why his pals call him the MP from Manhattan—Yashki gets more hits from NRIS rather than people closer home. "I am trying to sell both India's image and mine," he says. Even media-shy Finance Minister P. Chidambaram is realising the value of a virtual janata durbar. Only like the man himself, his personal site has no room for questions. Interestingly, Science and Technology Minister Kapil Sibal has a website devoted not to his ministry, but rather his constituency in Delhi's mofussil Chandi Chowk.

Today's leaders are realising that

with the blurring of ideology, it is not the party that sells as much as the power of the personality. It is a subtle shift to a more westernised campaign where it is not just an individual's politics but the entire package that is on display. On April 6 this year, BJP celebrated its Foundation Day with the launch of a website—only it was not about the party. In keeping with Advani's new-found stature as the PM-in-waiting, the site instead marketed his recent autobiography.

According to Alexa, a web information company that tracks website traffic, Rahul's site, launched in May 2007, ranks 35,76,976, while Advani's site launched in April 2008 is

at 1,80,51,170. Interestingly, the RSS site is way ahead of both at 7,94,515, having been launched in 1996. (A traffic rank computes a site's reach using the number of page views it gets.)

Blogs are slowly becoming a part of the outreach programme and in this age of instant soundbites, Omar Abdullah, MP and chief of the National Conference, is one of the pioneers. Writes Abdullah in his first blogpost, "With a certain amount of nervousness and trepidation, I am sending this first post." He fills his bit of cyberspace to write on state politics or about sipping coffee in one of India's most exclusive clubs—the Central Hall of Parliament.

Even Lalu Yadav, who has carefully nurtured the image of a rustic country cousin, is catwalking the digital ramp. His son's classmates have started a group on Facebook asking for Lalu to be made education minister. Writes a student, "He keeps getting weird ideas. Maybe he will ban the boards," while a schoolgirl simply adds, "He is hot."

No wonder all the leaders are fast logging onto politician.com. And the best of them know that the decisive battle is still in the real world where salvation doesn't come with the click of a mouse.

with bureau inputs